End-of-Year Binder Cleanout Ritual

A step-by-step send-off: celebrate the year, empty the backpack, start summer clean.

HOW TO USE THIS SHEET

Pick an afternoon in the last week of school and run this checklist once, top to bottom, ideally with hot chocolate or popsicles. It clears a year of paper in under two hours, saves one memory box per kid, and makes next August's setup week a relief instead of a dig through old folders. Do it while school still has a pulse — once that last bell rings, the backpack mysteriously becomes landfill.

RITUAL DATE: _____ **KID'S NAME & GRADE FINISHED:** _____ **TEACHER(S):** _____

PART 1 — CELEBRATE (15 MINUTES)

- ☐ Kid names one favorite day, field trip, or lunch this year — write it below
- ☐ Fly through the story of the year: report card, project, picture
- ☐ Pick the two or three projects worth framing and put straight into the keep pile

FAVORITE MOMENT THIS YEAR (KID'S WORDS):

_____

PART 2 — EMPTY THE BACKPACK (30 MINUTES)

- ☐ Backpack emptied over a sheet or towel: check every zip pocket, including the crumb drawer
- ☐ Lunchbox washed, water bottle run through the dishwasher (or thoroughly hand-washed and dried open)
- ☐ Lunch balance checked: refund requested or the leftover marked on the card (sheet 6)
- ☐ MONEY & FORMS folder confirmed empty — every billed activity is paid or cancelled
- ☐ Library books and classroom-lent items returned; textbooks confirmed with the teacher
- ☐ Electronic device / hotspot / library card returned per district schedule
- ☐ Medications picked up from the nurse's office — most schools destroy unclaimed meds
- ☐ Backpack and folders inspected: keep alive, or trashed and replaced guilt-free

PART 3 — SORT THE PAPER (30 MINUTES)

- ☐ MAKE MONEY pile: report card, certificates, writing samples, the picture that made you cry, one piece of art per month
- ☐ Everything else photographed at arm's length, then recycled (a copy box works well; keep a photo folder per year)
- ☐ KEEP ALL YEAR folder emptied into the home binder — schedules served their term
- ☐ Next-year list written: what the backpack was missing, what folder died, what you never found

PART 4 — SET UP NEXT YEAR (15 MINUTES)

- ☐ Memory box: one per kid, per year — dated label on the front
- ☐ New-to-next-year supplies boxed and shelved: the August-you present

- [ ] Backpack hung in its summer spot, stocked with one folder and one pencil (August's future problem, partially solved)
- [ ] This kit reprinted and re-pinned: sheets 1, 6, and 7 look different each year

NEXT-YEAR LIST (BACKPACK NEEDS, FOLDER REPLACEMENTS, LEFTOVER FEES):

Tip: the memory box matters more than the sweat-equity. One box per kid per year is a 15-minute tradition that beats a decade of guilt over a garage full of unsorted paper. Happy summer.